

October: A Computer Reaches Chess Grandmaster Level

By 1958, the game of chess had been computationally mapped. By now it was possible for computers to play chess and beat Grandmasters while they were at it! In 1988, the computers truly dominated the chess scene. The computer DEEP THOUGHT and Grandmaster Tony Miles shared first place in the US Open championship. Later in the year, the computer HITECH won the Pennsylvania State Chess Championship after defeating International Master Ed Formanek. It also defeated Grandmaster Arnold Denker in a match. By doing so, HITECH became the first chess computer to be rated Grandmaster strength.

Grandmaster Bent Larsen became the first GM to lose to a computer in a major tournament—the American Open. By November 1988, DEEP THOUGHT had a rating of 2550, better than any other Grandmaster of the era.

November: First Tablet PC

The Wang FreeStyle was debuted at the CHI'88 computer fair. This was the first tablet PC to be commercially available at the time. It was operated using a stylus instead of a mouse, and had a big monochrome display.

The tablet had a unique file system; files on the OS were not given names. Instead, thumbnails were displayed. Names were only used to identify e-mail contacts. Remarkably, this device allowed you to mash up your data to make it more meaningful; for example, the application called SIGGRAPH'89 allowed users to take a map and draw out a route on it using the stylus while explaining the route in a running commentary. The end document could be mailed out to anyone!

November: The Morris Worm

Robert Morris, a doctoral student at Cornell University, wrote one of the first computer viruses that spread itself via a network. When released, the virus would target VAX and Sun machines. Unlike some of today's viruses, it was not designed to cause harm to the computer: when a computer was infected, the virus would